

Reincarnations

As far back as a year ago we heard rumours that the PlayStation 4 would be based on the x86 architecture. Actually, x86-64, or what we've come to lovingly call x64. Important to desktop lovers like myself, because it allows us our ridiculous amounts of RAM – 16 GB for me. While some people seemed disappointed with the shift away from the PowerPC architectures, most of us were excited, because it meant that games would be easier to port from Windows to consoles, and who knows, if some really brilliant PS hackers have their way, maybe even Windows in dual-boot on a PlayStation? I know, improbable, but the past has taught me not to say impossible.

In late January, on vgleaks.com it was suggested that Microsoft's next console, codenamed Durango (or Xbox 720) will also be x86 (or x64) based. For Microsoft, obviously, this makes total sense. Like every other company around right now, they also want the interface to just disappear. Why does it have to matter if you're consuming content on your phone, a laptop/PC or on your console?

The ultimate idea is to put everything on the cloud, and allow it to be accessed on any of your devices, whether at home or on the go.

The biggest advantage of having the same platform as the PC is that more titles can be ported easily, and also developers will be working in a familiar environment when coding for the consoles. This is why the games that release just after a new console version are usually not the best in terms of graphics and physics, etc. Once developers really get dug into a new console, only then can they use the power at hand, and are able to tweak appropriately.

Not that we expect the x86-based consoles to be nothing more than desktop processors, because we're sure that tweaks and functionalities will be added on here and there to enhance things.

With x86 phones now available, the Lava Xolo for example, and Android making its way to desktops and smart TVs, the lines are blurring all across the place. And this is great for us consumers, because it means you will get a more integrated experience at the end of the day, and probably have to pay less money for not just the hardware, but also the software, as common platforms bring the development costs

of software down a big deal. It's the games that should get cheaper first, because developers spend a lot of time porting games to all platforms, and trying to take advantage of certain unique features or, say, a particular console.

Now for the bad news. People like me who have PlayStation 3 / Xbox 360 consoles, can probably forget about backwards compatibility. All the older game discs might not work anymore. However, I expect some of those games will be ported anyway, and most of them forgotten.

I don't really know how the rest of the world feels about this, but I rarely find myself going back to old games to replay them. All except Quake III Arena that is, but that's only because it's just the Team Digit way...

Speaking of reincarnations, most of you will notice a rather odd looking booklet with this issue of Digit. We had contemplated starting a lifestyle supplement a few years ago, but then pretty much forgot about it. It's not easy to bring out this much content on a monthly basis with the smallest team of writers I have ever seen for a magazine that holds the number one spot in any subject, but we're also known to be suckers for punishment.

If Digit is for the serious technology enthusiasts, looking to better their knowledge, further their career and learn, dgt is perhaps for those same people and more. Everyone needs to unwind sometimes, just oogle at gadget porn (and no, we will not be going down the tasteless half-dressed women route ever).

Although we take our technology seriously, we're also prone to desire, greed and temptation for some things, and logic and usefulness be damned. It's in that spirit that we're launching dgt this month, and we certainly hope you like it.

Keep in mind, however, that it's sort of like a beta, and we really look forward to your feedback to help make it even better and more relevant to as many people as we possibly can. Write in with suggestions please. 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

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Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and let me know your thoughts.